PHASE 1 • BRAINSTORMING & IDEATION

✓ VERIFIED SPECIFICATION

Empathy Map

AI-Powered Travel Planner • Smart Situational Itinerary Engine

Live URL: travel-planner-iota-plum.vercel.app **Repo:** github.com/itskian2007/travel-planner **Tech:** React + FastAPI + PostgreSQL **Team:** itskian2007

1. User Persona Profile • Primary Target Segment

A

Aarav Sharma, 27 • Tech Professional & Avid Traveler

PRIMARY PERSONA (70% OF USER BASE)

Demographics: Bengaluru, India • Software Engineer • Annual Travel Budget: $3,500 • Vacation Freq: 3-4x / Year

Core Motivation: Values authentic local culture and unique food, but works 50 hours a week and cannot afford to spend entire weekends researching travel blogs.

2. 4-Quadrant Empathy Map Board

SAYS (Explicit Statements)

- *"I just want an itinerary that knows I'm vegetarian and hate tourist traps."*
- *"Can someone give me Day 4 to 10? Every blog only covers Day 1 to 3."*
- *"I spent 4 hours on Reddit trying to figure out which subway pass to buy in Tokyo."*

THINKS (Internal Monologue)

- *"What if I book this luxury hotel and realize all attractions are 2 hours away?"*
- *"I hope I don't look like an idiot trying to order food with dietary constraints."*
- *"I want my trip to look like the real country, not an over-saturated Instagram reel."*

DOES (Observable Behavior)

- Opens 20 Chrome tabs simultaneously (Google Maps, TripAdvisor, Reddit, Wikipedia).
- Copies paste notes into a messy Google Sheet with broken links and no images.
- Abandons planning midway and books a rushed, generic tour package out of exhaustion.

FEELS (Emotional State)

- **Overwhelmed:** Drowning in conflicting reviews and sponsored recommendations.
- **Anxious:** Worried about hidden travel costs and dietary blunders.
- **Excited yet Drained:** High anticipation for the vacation, ruined by tedious planning.

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3. Pains vs. Gains Value Alignment

✕ USER PAIN POINTS

Frictions

• **Time Drain:** Sacrificing 5-8 hours of personal weekend time researching itineraries.
• **Dietary Anxiety:** Worrying if vegetarian/halal options exist near recommended attractions.
• **Static Templates:** Standard 3-day tourist guides that stop right when the vacation gets interesting.
• **Image Mismatches:** Misleading generic stock photos that look nothing like the destination.

✓ USER GAINS & DELIGHTS

Desired Value

• **Sub-Minute Planning:** Generating a fully structured 10-day itinerary in under 30 seconds.
• **Dietary Confidence:** Every lunch and dinner recommendation pre-filtered to user dietary profile.
• **Authentic Visuals:** Verified Wikipedia landmark photography providing truthful previews.
• **Situational Mood Sync:** Exploring Kyoto in "Cultural Calm" vs. Tokyo in "High Adventure".

4. Persona Empathy Synthesis Matrix

USER DIMENSION	OBSERVED FRICTION	ENGINEERED SYSTEM RESPONSE
Budget Confidence	Unsure how much each day truly costs beyond hotel bookings.	Dynamic budget tier calculator (Budget / Mid-Range / Luxury).
Food Compatibility	Fear of ending up in restaurants with zero dietary options.	Filter engine enforces Vegan, Vegetarian, Halal, or Gluten-Free tags.
Visual Trust	Skeptical of fake influencers and misleading travel photos.	304 non-duplicate Wikipedia commons verified photography pipeline.
Route Feasibility	Exhausting schedules with geographically impossible hops.	Basecamp clustering and curated Day 1-3 landmark sequences.